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The Abbot and the Doctors: Scholastic Reactions to the Radical Eschatology of Joachim of Fiore

BERNARD MCGINN

"Why are these fools awaiting the end of the world?" This remark, said to have been made by Pope Boniface VIII during the perusal of a Joachite treatise,¹ typifies what must have been the reaction of many thirteenth century popes to the eschatological groups of the time. With some notable exceptions,² the popes of the century were men from a single mold: lawyers, administrators, dynasty builders—men trained to expand the interests of the best organized and most efficient government in Europe, the church.³ Though it would be a serious error to see the concerns of these men as purely political, for religion and politics were mingled in the thirteenth century in inextricable fashion, there was a practicality and a sense of reality to the lawyer popes that shines through Boniface's impatient outburst at the visionary mutterings and interminable squabbles of those who thought the end was near.

This colorful incident is only meant to suggest that the diverging attitudes of an increasingly bureaucratic institution on the one hand and some of its more quixotic members on the other were coming into sharper and more evident opposition as the thirteenth century unfolded. But were the kinds of tensions evident between administrators and visionaries to be seen in other aspects of the life of the thirteenth century church? The question can only be made meaningful by becoming more precise. This paper will narrow it down to the arena of the history of ideas and specifically to the way in which the eschatological theories of the Abbot Joachim of Fiore (c. 1135-1202) were treated by the two most famous names in the history of thirteenth century Scholasticism, Thomas Aquinas (1225-1274) and Bonaventure of Bagnorea (1217-1274). The investigation will explore the relationship between eschatology and Scholasticism (deceptively equivocal terms) as one way of raising questions about the nature of the tensions between institutional immobility and charismatic impatience in the history of the church.

I. THE ABBOT JOACHIM

Joachim enthusiasts are frequently inclined to agree with the Italian scholar who called him the most fascinating figure of the middle ages. Agreement usually stops there. The perennial controversies in the large literature on Joachim are as daunting to the scholar as are the opacities and contradictions to be found in the abbot's surviving works. Clearly, it will not be possible to give full evidence

1. "Cur fatui expectant finem mundi?" Cited in H. Finke, *Aus den Tagen Bonifas VIII* (Münster, 1902), p. 222.
2. Especially Boniface's predecessor Celestine V (1294), the monk who was hailed by the Spiritual Franciscans as the long-awaited *pastor angelicus*. Cf. F. Baethgen, *Der Engelspapst: Idee und Erscheinung* (Leipzig, 1943), chaps. 2 and 3. E. Jordan "Joachim de Fiore," *Dictionnaire de Théologie Catholique*, VIII, c. 1446, claims that John XXI (1276-77) was also a sympathizer with the Joachite movement.
3. On the lawyer popes, cf. R. W. Southern, *Western Society and the Church in the Middle Ages* (Penguin Books, 1970), pp. 131-33.

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for the positions adopted here, nor, on most of the significant questions, can one appeal to anything like a consensus of scholarly opinion. It seems fair to warn the reader of this at the start. The positions taken will, I hope, be at least defensible ones. Given more time and space, it could perhaps be shown that they are also the most cogent ones.

That anyone from Calabria should have caused such a stir is surprising in itself, that it should have been the abbot of the obscure Cistercian monastery of Corazzo well-nigh incredible.⁴ In the early 1180s, partly as a result of visionary experiences and with the approval of the pope, Joachim began work on books designed to explain the concord or agreement of the Old and the New Testaments, the mystery of sacred history as contained in the Apocalypse, and the inner meaning of the Trinity. The abbot continued revising these three works—the *Concordia Novi ac Veteris Testamenti*, the *Expositio in Apocalypsim*, and the *Psalterium Decem Chordarum*—for many years, adding a number of minor treatises and an unfinished *Tractatus super Quatuor Evangelia* along the way. About 1190 he separated himself from the Cistercians and founded his own order at San Giovanni da Fiore in the remote and alpine Sila plateau of Calabria. Joachim had acquired a considerable reputation as a prophet during this time—popes, kings, and emperors gladly listened to the predictions which he said he made not through the gift of prophecy but through the spirit of understanding which God had given him.⁵

Three areas of theological interest dominate the abbot's thought: the theory of the senses of Scripture, the nature of the Trinity, and the meaning of history. There is still considerable disagreement about what he actually held on these questions. While some authors tend to dismiss Joachim's theory of the senses of Scripture under the general rubric of medieval allegory, the studies of H. Grundmann and H. de Lubac⁶ have shown that Joachim really broke with the traditional medieval theories of the four senses of Scripture, increasing the tally to twelve and placing great emphasis upon the seven "typical" senses by which events in each of the seven ages of history had literal "concordances" in the other six.⁷ The ability to work out the types or concords between the various ages was the gift of understanding by which Joachim claimed to know the future. For him prophecy was not needed; the secret was there in the *sacra pagina* for the man that God had enlightened. An understanding of Joachim's peculiar theory of Scripture is necessary for grasping the other areas of his theology,⁸ for to a traditionalist like the Abbot of Fiore theology and scriptural commentary were not yet differentiated functions—theology *was* the *sacra pagina*.

Patterns—patterns of twos and threes, of sevens and twelves—dominate

4. The most up-to-date treatment of Joachim's life is H. Grundmann, "Zur Biographie Joachims von Fiore und Rainers von Ponza," *Deutsches Archiv für Erforschung des Mittelalters*, 16 (1960), 437-546. The best bibliographical introduction to Joachim studies remains M. Bloomfield, "Joachim of Flora," *Traditio*, 13 (1957), 249-311.

5. For an analysis of these interviews, cf. M. Reeves, *The Influence of Prophecy in the Later Middle Ages: A Study of Joachimism* (Oxford, 1969), pp. 3-15.

6. H. Grundmann, *Studien über Joachim von Fiore* (Leipzig, 1927, photomechanical reprint, 1966), Chap. I, "Die Formen der Exegese und die Geschichtstheologie;" and H. de Lubac, *Exégèse Médiévale*, I, 2 (Paris, 1961), 437-558, especially 460-61.

7. For general background to the theory of the ages of history, cf. R. Schmidt, "Aetates mundi: Die Weltalter als Gliederungsprinzip der Geschichte," *Zeitschrift für Kirchengeschichte*, 67 (1955-56), 288-317.

8. One of the weaknesses of Reeves' informative book is to attempt to explain the abbot's theory of history and of the Trinity without such a treatment.

the strongly pictorial and symbolic mind of the abbot.⁹ The disagreement that still exists among scholars about the weight to be accorded to these various patterns is a major source of the differing judgments on the abbot's theology of the Trinity and of history. While the pattern of sevens retains an importance throughout Joachim's writings,¹⁰ it is the pattern of threes which eventually predominates. Indeed, in the case of Joachim's views on the Trinity, he has been accused of so letting the threes dominate that the unity of the Trinity is destroyed.¹¹

Modern research, especially that of A. Crocco, has clarified some of the problems connected with Joachim's trinitarian theology.¹² First of all, the supposition that Joachim was strongly influenced by Greek theology or by the School of Gilbert of Poitiers in this area appears very shaky indeed.¹³ His theology of the Trinity is an idiosyncratic reworking of traditional Latin sources with the presence of some of the exotic additions that are not untypical of other twelfth century Trinitarian theories.¹⁴ What is distinctive about Joachim's theology of the Trinity is what might be called its archaism. Strongly scriptural and symbolic in outlook, displaying an adequate, though not profound, knowledge of the Fathers, it was in conscious reaction against the Scholastic application of logical categories and distinctions to theology. Like Bernard of Clairvaux before him,¹⁵ Joachim seems to have felt threatened by the implications of the Scholastic enterprise.¹⁶ Joachim's reaction was even stronger than Bernard's, for while the Abbot of Clairvaux favored some of the more traditionally oriented Scholastics, like Hugh of St. Victor and Peter Lombard, Joachim's attack on the latter is the most evident proof of the intensity of his anti-Scholastic attitude. The book that Joachim wrote against Peter Lombard was condemned at the Fourth Lateran Council in 1215 and has not survived.¹⁷ We can, however, gather enough of the gist of his criticism from other remarks¹⁸ and from later discussions of the

9. Cf. especially M. Reeves, "The *Liber Figurarum* of Joachim of Fiore," *Mediaeval and Renaissance Studies*, 2(1950), 67-74.

10. He even devoted a separate treatise to it, the *De septem sigillis*, edited by M. Reeves and B. Hirsch-Reich, "The Seven Seals in the Writings of Joachim of Fiore," *Recherches de théologie ancienne et médiévale*, 21(1954), 211-47.

11. P. Fournier, *Études sur Joachim de Fiore et ses doctrines* (Paris, 1909), and C. Ottaviano in the preface to his edition of the pseudonymous *Liber Contra Lombardum* (Rome, 1934) both accuse Joachim of Tritheism.

12. A. Crocco, "La Formazione dottrinale di Gioacchino da Fiore e le Fonti della sua teologia Trinitaria," *Sophia*, 23(1955), 192-96; and "La Teologia Trinitaria di Gioacchino da Fiore," *Sophia*, 25(1957), 218-32. On the problem of Joachim's sources, cf. the summary in Bloomfield, *op. cit.*, 271-88.

13. The influence of Joachim's Trinitarian views may indeed work together with those of the School of Gilbert in the distinctive "Oriental" doctrinal complex described by M.-D. Chenu, "La dernier avatar de la théologie orientale en Occident au XIII^e siècle," *Mélanges Auguste Pelsaer* (Louvain, 1947), 159-81; but they are independent in origin.

14. E.g., the Jewish sources behind his theory of the Trinitarian circles uncovered by B. Hirsch-Reich, "Die Quelle der Trinitätskreise von Joachim von Fiore und Dante," *Sophia*, 22(1954), 170-78.

15. Joachim always displayed a very high opinion of St. Bernard and quoted his *De Consideratione* V, 7, with approval in the *Psalterium* (f. 234va) against the idea of a quaternity in God.

16. Joachim lashes out against Scholasticism in the *Expositio* (f. 87va) and in his last work, the *Super Quatuor Evangelia* (ed. E. Buonaiuti, No. 67 of the *Fonti per la Storia d'Italia*, Rome, 1930), 277, 296-97.

17. F. Foberti in his *Gioacchino da Fiore* (Florence, 1934), 98, claimed that this work, the *De essentia seu unitate Trinitatis*, was a Cistercian forgery. The claim has not been supported by other scholars. The *Liber contra Lombardum* edited by C. Ottaviano is not by Joachim at all, but is actually the earliest of the pseudo-Joachite works dating from approximately 1235.

18. The Lombard is criticized anonymously in the *Psalterium* (f. 229rb) and the *Expositio* (f. 34rb); and by name in the *Psalterium* (f. 277rb) and in the *De vita sancti Bene-*

condemnation to see that Joachim's accusation that Peter Lombard had destroyed the Trinity by making the divine essence really distinct from three persons results from a misunderstanding of the terminology and context of the Lombard's thought. Despite Crocco's rather large claims for the profundity of the abbot's Trinitarian views,¹⁹ Joachim's confusion here and in the matter of the divine relations, where he intermingles what would be later distinguished as procession and mission,²⁰ indicate that he was a traditionalist speaking out against new theological trends from a not very well informed position.

The real originality of the Abbot of Fiore is to be found in his theology of history. Scholars have long queried whether his Trinitarian theory, stressing the individuality of the three persons and confusing the processions and the missions as it does, is at the root of his views on history, or whether the opposite is the case.²¹ This seems to be yet another example of the priority of the chicken or the egg. From the logic of Christian theology, of course, Trinitarian theory must be prior; from the viewpoint of the genesis and development of Joachim's own thought it must be said that as far as we know the two interests develop simultaneously and mutually condition each other. Joachim's theology of history depends upon his theology of the Trinity throughout, but his theology of the Trinity would not have been what it was had he not seen the history expressed in the Scriptures as the revelation of the Trinitarian mystery and had he not found the key to the interpretation of this mystery in a more adequate theory of the senses of Scripture.

The exact nature of Joachim's ideas on history and their significance in the development of thirteenth century thought is still under dispute. Joachim is most famous, of course, for his theory of the three ages of history corresponding to the persons of the Trinity. To put it in his own words:

The First Age of the world began with Adam, flowered from Abraham, and was consummated in Christ. The Second began with Oziah, flowered from Zachary, the father of John the Baptist, and will receive its consummation in these times. The Third Age, taking its beginning from St. Benedict, began to bring forth fruit in the twenty-second generation, and is itself to be consummated in the consummation of the world. The First Age, in which the married state was illustrious, is ascribed to the Father in the personal aspect of the [Trinitarian] mystery. The Second, in which the clerical state in the tribe of Juda was illustrious, is ascribed to the Son; the Third, in which the monastic state is illustrious, is ascribed to the Holy Spirit.²²

M. Reeves has shown that a pattern of concordances between the two ages of the Old and the New Testaments also is to be found in the writings of the Abbot of Fiore.²³ The fact that both patterns are present (as well as the pat-

dicti, ed. C. Baraut, "Un tratado inédito de Joaquin de Fiore," *Analecta Sacra Tarraconnensia*, 24(1951), 77. Cf. Crocco, "La Teologia Trinitaria. . .," 225; and M. Reeves, *op. cit.*, 30-31.

19. "La Teologia Trinitaria. . .," 218.

20. Crocco himself notes this, "La Teologia Trinitaria. . .," 228-29. Cf. *Psalterium* (ff. 257vb; 260rb).

21. M. Bloomfield, *op. cit.*, 262-63.

22. *Concordia* IV, 33 (f. 56vb) (Venice, 1519, photomechanical reprint, 1964): Primus status seculi initiatus est ab Adam, fructificavit ab Aabraham, consumavit in Christo. Secundus initiatus ab Ocia, fructificavit ab Zacharia patre Joannis baptiste accepturus consumationem in temporibus istis. Tertius sumens initium a beato Benedicto. Cepit proferre fructum 22a generatione ab eodem sancto viro, consumandus et ipse in consumatione seculi. Et primus quidem in quo claruit ordo coniugatorum proprietate mysterii ascribitur patri. Secundus in quo claruit ordo clericorum in tribu iuda ascribitur filio. Tertius in quo claruit ordo monachorum ascribitur spiritui sancto.

23. M. Reeves, *Prophecy in the Later Middle Ages*, 129-32; and "The *Liber Figurarum* of Joachim of Fiore," 71-2; 75-77.

terns of sevens) show that Joachim's theories grew out of traditional thought on the nature of history: he only gradually arrived at his own understanding of the theory of the three ages, itself originally a traditional schema. Joachim's unique contribution was to see in the third age not just the future joy of paradise, or the age of the church begun at Pentecost, but the age of the fullness of revelation and the triumph of the *virī spirituales*, the "spiritual men."

The nature of this third age explains why Joachim's views can be characterized by the term "radical eschatology." All medieval thinkers were eschatological in the sense that they accepted the Christian understanding of history that looked forward to the definitive event of the return of Christ and the end of time. Joachim's sense of the imminence of his third age does not of itself make his thought distinctive;²⁴ from Gregory the Great²⁵ to Norbert of Xanten,²⁶ popes and saints had been convinced that all things were fulfilled and they themselves would live to see the end. But Joachim saw the terrors of the time of the Antichrist as presaging an age of completion within history and not outside it; after the persecutions of the man of iniquity, God would initiate the age of the Holy Spirit, the perfection of the divine action within history. Only after the third age would come the final tribulation and the sabbath rest of eternity.

The relationship of the third age to the second is the center of the most heated debates over just how radical Joachim's eschatology really is. Those who wish to preserve his fundamental orthodoxy, like F. Foberti, L. Tondelli, F. Russo, A. Crocco, and M. Reeves, claim that by the third age is meant nothing more than the purified church with its institutions and sacraments intact, in other words, Joachim is just another orthodox reformer. Other scholars, such as H. Grundmann, E. Benz, A. Dempf, B. Töpfer, M. Bloomfield, and H. de Lubac, see the third age as effecting serious changes in the institutions of the present church (especially with regard to the papacy, the sacraments, and the supremacy of the clerical order), and thus challenging the centrality of Christ in the divine scheme of salvation. Posed in these terms, despite the necessary correctives offered by the first group to the more extreme formulations of the second, it seems that the case for the latter position is more convincing. Perhaps the disagreement could be partially resolved if posed in the light of the institutional and social context of Joachim's thought, rather than in the value-laden contrast of heterodoxy vs. orthodoxy. From this vantage, it seems that the abbot's eschatological thought must be characterized as radical, because while always intending loyalty to the church of the second age (and allowing for at least some presence of such institutions as the papacy, the sacraments, and the clergy in the age to come), Joachim's stress on the domination of the spiritual and the charismatic over the institutional and rational in the future church was diametrically opposed to the forces that triumphed during the thirteenth century. The term "radical" then is taken to signify a type of relation between thought and its institutional and social context in which the implementation of the thought would effect drastic changes in the mode of institutional operation and the theoretical justifications used for

24. He himself refused to predict a definite date. The closest that he comes to it is in *Concordia* (f. 118r), but the cautions expressed in ff. 63va, 67vb, and 118ra express his real mind. The noted *Liber Figurarum* which seems to emanate partly from Joachim's own hand and partly from his immediate circle makes the identification more definite, cf. Tavola IV, in L. Tondelli, M. Reeves, and B. Hirsch-Reich, *Il Libro delle Figure*. Vol. II, Tavole (Turin, 1953²).

25. Gregory I, *Registrum* III, 29 (*MGH. Ep. I*, 187).

26. Bernard, *Epistola* LVI (*P.L.* 182, c. 162).

such operations. In this sense the concept of the third age in the writings of Joachim of Fiore was a radical critique of the thirteenth century church. Whether "radical" may also mean "heretical" or not, I will leave to the judgment of those who are able to educe a-temporal definitions of orthodoxy.

II. THE SCHOLASTIC REACTION

Publications of the last fifteen years, especially those of R. Manselli, B. Töpfer, G. Leff, and M. Reeves,²⁷ have made it possible to write the history of thirteenth century eschatology with some degree of accuracy. The thought of the Abbot Joachim is obviously the most important single influence on the growth of this eschatological current. Most of the thirteenth century eschatological texts are *Joachite* in the sense that they are influenced by the body of ideas claiming Joachim as its source, though they may not be *Joachimist*, that is, truly in harmony with the authentic writings and major ideas of the Abbot of Fiore.²⁸ This distinction should be kept in mind when we consider the reaction of Scholastic writers to radical eschatology. Because of the presence of so many pseudonymous treatises, the lack of critical historical sense in analyzing texts, and the Scholastic habit of vague and anonymous references (*quidam dixit*), in most cases we will be dealing with reactions to the Joachite tradition in general; only rarely can we be sure that a particular author is referring to a genuine work of Joachim.

Three periods in the history of the thirteenth century Joachite movement may be distinguished.²⁹ In the first period, from 1202 to the early 1240s, Joachim is chiefly famous as the prophet of the Antichrist and the object of the condemnation of the Fourth Lateran Council. Beginning in the 1240s with the inauthentic commentary, *Super Hieremiam Prophetam*, and the ideas of such Franciscans as Hugh of Digne, John of Parma, and especially Gerardo di Borgo San Donnino, the themes of the three ages of history and the imminence of the third age come to the fore.³⁰ While these are truly Joachimist in origin, they were overlaid with explanations and specifications which significantly altered³¹ and frequently gravely perverted³² the thought of the Abbot of Fiore. The condemnation of Gerardo's *Introductorius in Evangelium Aeternum* by Alexander

27. R. Manselli, *La Lectura super Apocalypsim di Pietro Giovanni Olivi: Ricerche sull'escatologismo medioevale* (Rome, 1955); B. Töpfer, *Das kommende Reich des Friedens* (Berlin, 1964); G. Leff, *Heresy in the Later Middle Ages*, 2 Vol. (N.Y., 1967); and M. Reeves, *The Influence of Prophecy*. . . .

28. This distinction, though difficult to apply in practice, is necessary given the proliferation of works falsely ascribed to the abbot. Both Reeves and Leff generally use the term "Joachimist" to refer to what is here called "Joachite," but without making a distinction such as the one suggested here. My plea for this idiosyncrasy is not only the necessity for an adequate, if abstract, distinction, but also the recollection that Salimbene generally refers to those caught up in such speculations as *Joachitae*.

29. This division owes much to the valuable work of Reeves, but the three periods are only implicit in her summaries, e.g., *op. cit.*, 151-53, 185-88, 302-07.

30. Another important theme that began to receive emphasis at this time was Joachim's supposed prophecy of the two mendicant orders. Joachim had seen the role of the monastic *virī spirituales* who would usher in the third age as a double one: pure contemplation on the one hand, and the work of preaching on the other. Hence he usually spoke of two coming monastic orders: e.g., *Concordia* (ff. 68v, 71v-72r, 76v); *Expositio* (ff. 175-v-176r); and *Tractatus* (ed. Buonaiuti, 99, 164-65). Cf. M. Reeves, *op. cit.*, 141-44. The mendicant transformations of this will be outlined below.

31. Among these may be mentioned: (1) the setting of a definite date for the initiation of the third age; (2) the identification of the two orders of the transitional period with the Franciscans and Dominicans; and (3) the beginning of concentration on poverty as the eschatological sign.

32. E.g., Gerardo's claim that the New Testament had been abrogated by the three major works of Joachim, the *Evangelium Aeternum*, which was to be the written scripture of the third age.

IV at Anagni in 1255 and the passing of the fatal year 1260 which was to mark the beginning of the third age ushered in what might be called the classical phase of the Joachite movement. As undaunted as any other prophetic system by the mere passing of the predicted date for the end, eschatological thought stressing the pattern of three ages (as well as the pattern of the double seven ages of the two Testaments) became the foundation for an important series of treatises, many ascribed to Joachim, in the latter part of the century. This activity, of course, was most evident in the Franciscan order. It would be a mistake, however, to restrict the history of the Joachite movement after 1240 to the history of the Spiritual Franciscans. Joachite thought appealed to a wide variety of thinkers, and many of its shifts of emphasis away from authentic Joachimism in the second half of the century are not specifically Franciscan.³³

This strong eschatological movement, however, flourished in the midst of a century that is not unjustly known as the age of the triumph of Scholasticism. In exploring the relations between these two systems of ideas, we are confronted by the difficulty that Scholasticism is almost as elusive of definition as eschatology. Is it a method, an attitude, or a particular set of conclusions? Obviously, a bit of all three. It will be taken here in the sense of a particular way of doing theology—the application of the differentiation inherent in the methods of the *lectio*, *quaestio*, and *disputatio* to the task of achieving a new organization and synthesis of the knowledge of the Christian faith. The men here termed Scholastics are not only those trained in such methods and outlook (which would include most of the thinkers of the century, other systems of education being largely in decline), but those who actively taught and wrote in these rigorous and demanding categories of thought, i.e., *magistri scholarum*.

The same research that has gradually exposed the history of the Joachite current in the thirteenth century has tended to emphasize that there is no single Scholastic reaction to radical eschatology. It has long been known that Peter John Olivi (c. 1248-1298), the most important thirteenth century eschatological theorist after Joachim himself, was a highly-regarded theologian, the author of a significant *Commentary on the Sentences*, and a teacher in Franciscan houses for many years. There were, of course, *magistri*, such as David of Augsburg,³⁴ and Peter of Apulia in the famous story of Salimbene,³⁵ who felt that the whole eschatological wave was nonsense; there were others who maintained a cool and critical attitude towards it, like Thomas of Pavia³⁶ and Henry of Harclay.³⁷ Many of the well known teachers of the century, alongside their technical Scholastic treatises, found time to record their eschatological expectations in treatises and letters. John Quidort (d. 1306), the noted ecclesiologist of Paris,³⁸ and

33. On the way in which the Spiritual Franciscans used Joachite thought for their own purposes, cf. Leff, *op. cit.* I, 68-83; 122-39; 153-54; 174-91. Leff's conclusion is that "Franciscan content had usurped Joachist form" (p. 190). Among the less specifically Franciscan developments in the Joachite tradition in this period are: (1) the increasingly virulent criticism of the present papacy; (2) the growing emphasis on the role of the reforming pope (*pastor angelicus*) who would usher in the third age; and (3) the shift towards political prophecy and emphasis on the figure of the last world emperor. The old book of G. Bondatti, *Gioachinismo e Francescanismo nel Duecento* (S. Maria degli Angeli, 1924) is still useful on Franciscan Joachitism.

34. Cf. Reeves, *op. cit.*, 53.

35. *Chronica* (ed. O. Holder-Egger), *MGH.SS.* XXXII, 239 sqq.

36. Reeves, *op. cit.*, 52-53; 185-86.

37. F. Pelster, "Die Quaestio Heinrichs von Harclay über die zweite Ankunft Christi," *Archivio italiano per la storia della pietà*, 1(1951), 25-82; and Reeves, *op. cit.*, 315-17.

38. Reeves, *op. cit.*, 315-16.

Robert d'Uzès (d. 1296),³⁹ a Dominican theologian, are among this group.

Perhaps it may be said that this list of figures of the second and third rank among Scholastic writers of the century does not tell the tale. After all, none of these men exercised a major influence on the history of medieval thought, and their eschatological attitudes may not be characteristic of the great thinkers. Therefore it may be worthwhile to pursue the question with Thomas Aquinas and Bonaventure, the most important Scholastic writers of the thirteenth century.

A. THOMAS AQUINAS

William of Tocco describes the following incident in his life of Thomas Aquinas:

Since it was from the sayings of the Abbot Joachim that the aforementioned heretics [those who believed in the "new spirit of liberty"] received the stimulant of that poisonous error, our Doctor sought out Joachim's book in a certain monastery, and when it was presented read the whole thing through. Wherever he found anything erroneous or suspect, he condemned it with underlining. He forbade that the book be read or believed and nullified its teachings with his own hand.⁴⁰

The authenticity of this incident is reinforced by a study of the text of the angelic doctor, for of all the Scholastic authors his reaction to Joachim and the Joachites is by far the most consistently hostile. Thomas was a bachelor of the Sentences at Paris, a young professor working for his master's chair, when the first major crisis of radical eschatology broke at the University. The publication in 1254 of the *Introductorius in Evangelium Aeternum* of Gerardo di Borgo San Donino, a Franciscan student of theology at the university, provided a convenient handle for attacks on the mendicants by the disgruntled secular masters.⁴¹ Fortunately for the mendicants, the chief spokesman for the seculars, William of St. Amour, turned out to be almost as radical in his eschatology as Gerardo⁴² and so intemperate in his language that he too was subject to papal condemnation in 1256. It is within this context that Aquinas' initial reaction against Joachite thought must be seen.

In the fourth book of his *Commentary on the Sentences* (1256),⁴³ Aquinas devotes a brief discussion to what in the long run is the fundamental point of all radical eschatologies—the ability to predict the end of the world with security.⁴⁴ While the treatment is generalized, it seems safe to say that his at-

39. Cf. J. Bignami-Odier, "Les visions de Robert d'Uzès, O. P.," *Archivum Fratrum*

40. *AASS*. Martius 7, p. 665: Et quia ex dictis Abbatis Joachim praedicti haeretici

40. *AASS*. Martius 7, p. 665: Et quia ex dictis Abbatis Joachim praedicti haeretici fomentum sumunt praefati erroris pestiferi, praedictus Doctor in quodam monasterio petivit librum praefati Abbatis, et oblatum totum perlegit, et ubi aliquid erroneum reperit vel suspectum, cum linea subducta damnavit, quod totum legi et credi prohibuit, quod ipse sua manu docta cassavit. Although William's account (which dates from about 1320) is obviously colored by John XXII's struggle against the Spiritual Franciscans, there is no reason to doubt the authenticity of the story. On the value of Tocco's life, cf. K. Foster, *The Life of Aquinas* (Baltimore, 1959), 6-13.

41. On this quarrel, cf. D. Douie, *The Conflict between the Seculars and Mendicants at the University of Paris in the 13th Century* (London, 1954), Aquinas Society Paper No. 23; and Y. Congar, "Aspects ecclésiologiques de la querelle entre mendiants et séculiers dans la seconde moitié du XIIIe siècle et le début du XIVe," *Archives d'histoire doctrinale et littéraire du moyen âge*, 36(1961), 35-151.

42. William's *De periculis novissimi temporis* saw the mendicants themselves as the sign of the approach of the Antichrist.

43. The *Commentary* was delivered from 1254-56; one would expect the texts from the *Commentary on the Fourth Book* to date from the end of the period.

44. In *IV Sent.* d.43, q.1, a.3, quaestiuncula 2, "Videtur quod tempus illud non sit occultum." On the dating of St. Thomas' works there are convenient summaries in I. T. Eschmann, "A Catalogue of St. Thomas' Works," in E. Gilson, *The Christian*

tack on this doctrine is directed against the followers of Joachim, since both the second and third affirmative arguments bear a distinctly Joachite flavor.⁴⁵ Nevertheless, there is no explicit condemnation of Joachim nor unequivocal mention of the doctrine of the third age. While the reaction of Thomas to the central point at issue is thus clear from the beginning, another text shows Thomas' nuanced viewpoint with respect to the predictions circulating under the name of the Abbot of Fiore. In d. 43, q. 1, a. 3, quaestiuncula 4, sol. II, ad 3, Joachim is mentioned by name. Aquinas' point is that comparison between the Old and the New Testaments can only be general—all the figures of the Old Testament find their fulfillment in Christ. Those who seek a point-for-point concordance are in error, as Augustine noted with regard to the conjectures of those who compared the ten plagues of the Exodus with the ten persecutions of the early church (*De Civitate Dei* XVIII, 52). "And the same seems true about the sayings of the Abbot Joachim who predicted some truths about future events through such conjectures, and was deceived in others."⁴⁶ Two things are worthy of notice here: first, the appeal to Augustine; and then, the assertion that the abbot had predicted some truths. It is quite possible that what Aquinas had in mind here was the famous Joachite prophecy of the two orders that were to herald the third age.⁴⁷ This prophecy had become an important part of the propaganda of the Franciscans and Dominicans,⁴⁸ and Thomas may not have been inclined to disavow it at a time when the mendicants were under attack.

The angelic doctor deepened his objections to the fundamental principles of radical eschatology in a treatise written in response to the attacks on the mendicants in late 1256, the *Contra Impugnantes Dei Cultum et Religionem*.⁴⁹ William of St. Amour had said that the mendicants were the heralds of the Antichrist; Thomas refutes the idea that the Antichrist is nigh and that the mendicants can be specifically said to be his heralds. The first half of this argument (paragraphs #529-42), with its heavy dependence on Augustine's *Letter to Hesychius*,⁵⁰ is his longest response to radical eschatology, for Aquinas' attack here is not only directed against the secular masters, but also against the ideas of Gerardo di Borgo San Donnino. Joachim himself is mentioned, but in a way that leads one to believe that Aquinas realized that, however dangerous the abbot's doctrines were, the Joachites had gone far beyond them.⁵¹ It is evident

Philosophy of St. Thomas Aquinas (N.Y., 1965), 381-430; and M.-D. Chenu, *Toward Understanding St. Thomas* (Chicago, 1963), Part II, *passim*.

45. The first argument is Aristotelian, citing a text from the *De Generatione*. The second argument is based upon the year 1260, while the third depends on the prefiguration of the New Testament in the Old—both Joachite themes. For further texts on the impossibility of knowing the time of the end, cf. *In IV Sent.* d.47, q.1, a.1, quaestiuncula 3; d.48, q.1, a.4, quaestiuncula 4, ad 2; and d.48, q.2, a.2, ad 8.

46. Et similiter videtur esse de dictis Abbatis Joachim, qui per tales conjecturas de futuris aliqua vera praedixit, et in aliquibus deceptus fuit.

47. Joachim's prophecy of two monastic orders, one contemplative, one active, was referred to in note 30 above. The pseudonymous works, beginning with the *Super Hieremiam Prophetam* (e.g., ff. 12v sqq.), changed this to two preaching orders, not unexpectedly looking very much like the Franciscans and Dominicans. Cf. Reeves, *Prophecy in the Later Middle Ages*. . . , 145-60.

48. Reeves argues that this Joachite theme and the symbolism in which it was expressed were at the basis of the joint encyclical letter issued by the generals of the two orders in 1255. Cf., *op. cit.*, 146-48.

49. Text in *Opuscula Theologica*, Vol. II (Marietti ed.), 5-110 Cf. P. Glorieux, "Le 'Contra Impugnantes' de St. Thomas. Ses sources, son plan," *Mélanges Mandonnet* I (Paris, 1930), 51-81.

50. *Epist.* CXCIX, *CSEL* 57, 243-92. .

51. Unde cum quidam iam Christi Evangelium mutare conentur in quoddam aliud evan-

from the text that the angelic doctor was aware of the condemnation of the *Introductorius* of Gerardo in 1255; later texts will show that he had read the document of condemnation, the Protocoll of Anagni.⁵² Aquinas' ability to distinguish between Joachim and his followers suggests that he was also familiar with some of the actual texts of the abbot, as Tocco avers.

Thomas' Italian period (1259 to 1268) shows him consolidating the position already adopted against the Joachite vision of history⁵³ and widening his attack to include a detailed treatment of the abbot's Trinitarian views. In response to an unknown correspondent, Thomas commented on the decretal of the Fourth Lateran Council which had condemned Joachim's attack on Peter Lombard. The *Commentary* shows an incisive awareness of Joachim's main problem, his non-Scholastic mentality: "Joachim the Abbot of the monastery of Fiore, not really grasping the words of the aforesaid master, since he was uninstructed in the subtle dogmas of the faith, held that the doctrine of Master Peter was heretical. . . ."⁵⁴

Thomas' second period in Paris (1269-72) brought all these insights together in systematic fashion in the *Summa*. Joachim's Trinitarian errors are dealt with in q. 39, a. 5 of the *Prima Pars*, "Whether essential names signified in the abstract are able to stand for the [divine] Person." In its clarity and brevity the article shows an advance over the more diffuse treatment of the *In Decretalem Secundum Expositio*.⁵⁵ The summation of Thomas' opposition to radical eschatological expectations of a third age is to be found in q. 106, a. 4 of the *Prima Secundae* (c. 1269-70): "Whether the New Law is to last until the end of the World?" E. Benz has shown how this article proves Aquinas' acquaintance with the Protocoll of Anagni and the excerpts from Joachim's works made for the Commission. Thomas' classic defense of the traditional viewpoint in turn became a key source of later condemnations of eschatological views, especially those of Peter John Olivi.⁵⁶ Although Joachim is not mentioned by name, the four affirmative arguments are classic expressions of the Joachite position.⁵⁷ Thomas'

gelium quod dicunt aeternum, manifeste dicunt instare tempora Antichristi. Hoc autem evangelium de quo loquuntur, est quoddam introductorium in libros Ioaachim compositum, quod est ab Ecclesia reprobatur; vel etiam ipsa doctrina Ioaachim, per quam, ut dicunt, Evangelium Christi mutatur. (ed. cit., #533, p. 105). Immediately below (#534) Thomas says that although the doctrine of Joachim or of the *Introductorius* contain many reprehensible things, it is false to assert that it is the doctrine that will be preached by the Antichrist, as William had said.

52. Edited by H. Denifle, "Das Evangelium Aeternum und die Kommission zu Anagni," *Archiv für Literatur und Kirchengeschichte*, 1(1885), 49-142.

53. Especially in the long *quaestio disputata* (c. 1265) "Utrum possit sciri ab homine quando motus caeli finiatur." *De Potentia*, q.5, a.6.

54. Joachim autem Abbas Florentis monasteri non bene capiens verba Magistri praedicti, utpote in subtilibus fidei dogmatibus rudis, praedictam Magistri Petri doctrinam haereticam reputavit. . . . *In Decretalem secundum Expositio, Opera Omnia* XVI, 308 (Parma ed.). Joachim is also mentioned in the *Contra Errores Graecorum*, chap. 4 (*Opera Omnia* XV, 241), dating from 1263. Aquinas makes a point here that he will return to in *S.Th.* Ia,q.39, a.5, ad 1, viz., that Joachim has patristic tradition on his side in using expressions like "essentia generat essentiam," but that these older modes of expression are no longer adequate. As the *Summa* text puts it: Unde huiusmodi locutiones non sunt extendendae, sed exponendae.

55. Respondeo dicendum quod circa hoc erravit Abbas Joachim, asserens quod, sicut dicitur, "Deus genuit Deum," ita potest dici quod "essentia genuit essentiam. . ." Sed in hoc deceptus fuit: quia ad veritatem locutionum, non solum oportet considerare res significatas, sed etiam modum significandi. . . .

56. E. Benz, "Joachim-Studien III. Thomas von Aquin und Joachim de Fiore," *Zeitschrift für Kirchengeschichte*, 53(1934), 52-116.

57. It seems that the second and third arguments, stressing the third age as the fullness of revelation without mentioning the abrogation of the Gospel of Christ, can also be said to represent the Joachimist position, as well as the Joachite.

insistence on two and only two periods of the law is founded upon theological analysis, careful consideration of a formidable series of scriptural texts,⁵⁸ and a battery of patristic authors.⁵⁹

The confrontation between the abbot and the doctor is well nigh perfect. Aquinas denies Joachim's method of scriptural interpretation by types and concordances,⁶⁰ he rejects his Trinitarian views, and destroys his concept of the three ages of history. His argument is consistent and seems to have been based on some knowledge of Joachim's text, as well as on the condemnation of the radical Joachite *Introducorius* at Anagni. Christ's centrality is stressed in the Thomistic view of the history of salvation in a way that is just that much clearer than the earlier tradition insofar as it has had to meet the challenge of the Joachite system.⁶¹ The severe contrast between Joachim and Thomas has led to a similar split in the judgments of modern historians. A. Dempf, E. Buonaiuti, E. Benz, and more recently T. Gregory have seen in Thomas' opposition to the abbot a sign of the loss of the historical and eschatological dimensions of Christianity in Scholasticism.⁶² Thomist scholars, on the other hand, like Y. Congar, M. D. Chenu, and M. Secklar, have risen up in defense of the doctor claiming that he saved the true dimensions of *Heilsgeschichte* in Christianity by attacking the false variety spawned by Joachim.⁶³ Whether Aquinas preserved the basic categories of *Heilsgeschichte* within the a-historical form of Scholastic theology is too complex a question to enter into here, but Gregory is surely correct to stress the individualizing and cosmologizing effect that Aristotelian physics had upon the Scholastic treatment of the last things.⁶⁴ Thomas' opposition to predictions of the near approach of the end and his refusal to join in the search for eschatological signs in history are as much Augustinian as they are Scholastic. The African bishop also lived in a time of fervent eschatological awareness and reacted against it with equal vigor.⁶⁵ Commentators have tended to overlook the depth of the influence of Augustinian texts on this aspect of Aquinas'

58. Of the fourteen scriptural quotations discussed in the article only those from Mt. 24, 14, and 24, 34-36 show some connection with the treatments in the Scriptural commentaries belonging to the same second Paris period. Cf. *Expositio in Matthaeum*, XXIV, #1; #3 (*Opera Omnia* X, 217; 223-24).

59. Besides Augustine, Chrysostom and the Pseudo-Dionysius are used. The text from the Pseudo-Dionysius, *Ecc. Hier.* V, 2, was a very popular one with Aquinas, as Y. Congar demonstrates in "Le Sens de l'économie salutaire dans la théologie de St. Thomas d'Aquin (*Somme théologique*)," *Festgabe Joseph Lortz: II. Glaube und Geschichte* (Baden-Baden, 1958), 86-89.

60. It may be possible that *Quaestiones Quodlibetales* VII, q. 6, a.15, ad 1, is an attack on Joachim's typical sense. To the objection that the Scriptures have only an historical sense, because figurative statements are not only applied to Christ, but also to others, Aquinas replies that if *similitudines imaginariae* are applied to others the sense must be historical, if applied to Christ the sense is allegorical. Thus Christ's position maintains a supremacy for Aquinas that it does not have with Joachim.

61. On Christ's centrality in Aquinas, cf. Y. Congar, *op. cit.*, 81, 112; and J. Ratzinger, *Die Geschichtstheologie des heiligen Bonaventuras* (Munich, 1959), 118-19.

62. A. Dempf, *Sacrum Imperium* (Munich, 1929), 395; E. Buonaiuti, "Gioacchino da Fiore, San Bonaventura, San Tommaso," *Ricerche Religiose*, 6 (1930), 296-97; E. Benz, *op. cit.*, 115-16; and T. Gregory, "Sull'escatologia di Bonaventura e Tommaso d'Aquino," *Studi Medievali*, 3rd Series, 6 (1965), 89-90.

63. M.-D. Chenu, "Histoire et allegorie au douzième siècle," *Festgabe J. Lortz. II. Glaube und Geschichte*, 64-65, 70-71; M. Secklar, *Das Heil in der Geschichte: Geschichtstheologisches Denken bei Thomas von Aquin* (Munich, 1964), 189-95; and especially Y. Congar, *op. cit.*, *passim*.

64. T. Gregory, *op. cit.*; and "Escatologia e Aristotelismo nella Scolastica Medievale," *Giornale Critico della Filosofia Italiana*, 10 (1961), 163-74.

65. Cf. J. Hubaux, "St. Augustin et la crise eschatologique de la fin du IV^e siècle," *Académie Royale de Belgique Bulletin de la classe des lettres et des sciences morales et politiques*, 5th Series, 40 (1954), 658-74.

thought.⁶⁶ Over and over again in the anti-Joachite passages he returns to the same series of authorities: the *Epistola ad Hesychium*,⁶⁷ the *Liber LXXXIII Quaestionum*,⁶⁸ and the *De Civitate Dei*.⁶⁹ If Aquinas is anti-historical here, it would seem that Augustine must be tarred with the same brush. Not even the angelic doctor is always consistent, however, because on at least one occasion he does interpret an eschatological sign in terms of the concrete historical present, in a sense that fully accords with the outlook of the thirteenth century papal monarchy that was Aquinas' patron.⁷⁰

B. BONAVENTURE

If Scholasticism were to be defined as the thought of Thomas Aquinas, then the same opposition between radical eschatology and ecclesiastical institutionalism which was evident in the papal reaction also held good in the intellectual sphere. But a consideration of the thought of Bonaventure presents quite a different version of the attitude of a Scholastic thinker to the Abbot of Fiore.

Despite the fact that Joachite ideas were strongest in the Franciscan Order, Bonaventure's *Commentary on the Sentences* (c. 1250-52)⁷¹ shows no awareness of the abbot's eschatology; unlike Thomas' *Commentary*, however, it criticizes Joachim's faulty Trinitarian theology.⁷² Although Bonaventure's academic period seems strangely free of influences from Joachim's visions of history, the events of the crisis of 1254-57 were to plunge him into the midst of eschatological controversy in a far more profound way than Aquinas ever experienced and to compel him to make decisions which altered the course of his future theological effort in a significant fashion.

John of Parma had been the Minister General of the Franciscans since 1247. Testimony to his personal qualities, as well as his ability to moderate between the incipient Spiritual wing of the order and the more conservative majority, are almost universal. John had, however, taken a stand in favor of the Joachite interpretation of the coming of the future age and the role that the Franciscans were to play in it. The condemnation of Gerardo's *Introductorius* left him in an embarrassed position. In February of 1257 John, at papal prompting, laid down his charge at the General Chapter and nominated Bonaventure as his suc-

66. It is, however, briefly noted in J. Ratzinger, *op. cit.*, 118-19.

67. Cited in *In IV Sent.* d.47, q.1, a.1, quaestiuncula 3, Sol. III, ad 2; d.48, q.1, a.4, quaestiuncula 4; *Contra Impugnantes* #530-31, 541-42; *De Pot.* q.5, a.6c; *In Matt.* XXIV, #3; *In Epist. II ad Thess.* II, 1.1; and *Ia IIae*, q.106, a.4, ad. 4.

68. *Quaestio* 58 is cited in *In IV Sent.* d.47, q.1, a.1, quaestiuncula 3, Sol. III, ad 3; and in *De Pot.* q.5, a.6, ad 1. *Quaestio* 60 is cited in *Contra Impugnantes* #532.

69. *De Civitate Dei* XVIII, 52-53 is found in *In IV Sent.* d.43, q.1, a.3, quaestiuncula 4, Sol. II; and in *Contra Impugnantes* #536.

70. In commenting on II Thess. 2, 3, he adverts to the interpretation of the *Glossa Ordinaria* that the *discessio* that must take place before the end will be a departure from the rule of the Roman Empire. The text continues: Sed quomodo est hoc? Quia jamdiu Gentes recesserunt a Romano Imperio, et tamen necdum venit Antichristus. Dicendum est, quod nondum cessavit, sed est commutatum de temporali in spirituale, ut dicit Leo Papa in sermone de Apostolis. Et ideo dicendum est, quod discessio a Romano Imperio debet intelligi non solum a temporali sed a spirituali, scilicet a fide catholicae Romanae Ecclesiae." *Opera Omnia* XIII, 577.

71. For the dating of Bonaventure's works, cf. G. de Bougerol, *An Introduction to the Works of St. Bonaventure* (N.Y., 1963), 171-77.

72. . . . ignoranter Joachim reprehendit Magistrum [Peter Lombard] et quia, cum esset simplex, non est reveritus Magistrum, ideo iusto Dei iudicio damnatus fuit libellus eius in Lateranensi concilio et positio Magistri approbata. *In I Sent.* dist. 5, dub. 4, cf. *Opera Omnia* (Quarrachi ed.) I, 121. (Compare with Aquinas' treatment of the same distinction, *In I Sent.* d.5, q.1, a.1 and a.2.)

cessor. The new minister was later to conduct a trial of his predecessor and friend that resulted in his condemnation.

A bare recounting of the events scarcely does justice to the difficult position in which Bonaventure found himself. For one whose major commitment was to the future of the order of Francis, dangers had to be met simultaneously on a number of fronts. Radical Joachites had to be treated with a harshness that may appal the modern reader, but the Joachite vision which had contributed so much to the success of the Franciscans must also be in some way preserved. Bonaventure's career as Minister General (1257-74) was an heroic attempt to achieve these conflicting goals.

The seraphic doctor's interest in appropriating the force of the Joachite vision in the service of the Franciscan order without falling into the errors of the radical Joachites first appears in unmistakable fashion in his identification of Francis with the "Angel of the Sixth Seal" of Apocalypse 7, 2 in the life of Francis known as the *Legenda Maior* (1261).⁷³ The same identification is found in the roughly contemporary *Legenda Minor*.⁷⁴ The identification of Francis with the angel who ushers in the sixth and crucial age of history recurs in the later writings of Bonaventure,⁷⁵ but it is the inclusion of this identification within the framework of an ever-enlarging adaptation and appropriation of the Joachite scheme of history which makes the seraphic doctor an important witness to one form of the confrontation of the abbot and the Scholastic world. J. Ratzinger has argued that even before his election as Minister General, Bonaventure was developing themes, particularly on the eschatological significance of poverty, which prepared him for a fruitful encounter with Joachite thought.⁷⁶ Given the saint's absorption with administrative details during much of his later life, we must wait until the *Collationes in Hexaemeron*, delivered to the community at Paris during the months of April and May, 1273, for the full expression of this appropriation.⁷⁷

73. The Angel of the Sixth Seal had played a minor role in the authentic writings of Joachim where he is identified with the future *pastor angelicus*, cf. *Expositio* (f. 120vb); and *Concordia* (f. 56rb). According to the later testimony of Ubertino of Casale and Bernardino of Siena, John of Parma was the first to identify the angel with Francis. The Protocoll of Anagni tells us that Gerardo made the same identification, cf. Denifle, *op. cit.*, 101; 120; 131. But it was clearly Bonaventure's adherence to the theme which gave it a central place in Franciscan eschatology, cf. *Legenda Maior*, Prologus #1; and chap. 13 (*Opera Omnia* VIII, 504; 545). The most complete treatment of this theme is to be found in S. Bihel, "S. Franciscus fuitne Angelus Sexti Sigilli?", *Antonianum*, 2(1927), 57-90.

74. *Legenda Minor*, "De Transitu Mortis," 1.1. and 1.9 (*Opera Omnia* VIII, 577, 579).

75. The most noted example of the identification took place in a sermon given at the General Chapter held at Paris in 1266. The text has not survived, but there is no reason to doubt the testimony of Olivi as to the fact, cf. S. Bihel, *op. cit.*, 66-67. The identification is also found in the *Collationes in Hexaemeron* XVI, 16 (*Opera Omnia* V, 405), though in a more general fashion. On appearances in Bonaventure's sermons, cf. Bihel, *op. cit.*, 65-66.

76. E.g., *Quaestiones Disputatae de Perfectione Evangelii*, q.2, a.2, Conclusio #20 (*Opera Omnia* V, 147-49), written before 1256 according to de Bougerol, *op. cit.*, 118. On this question, cf. J. Ratzinger, *op. cit.*, 111, 115-16. Bonaventure was also beginning to speculate on the theory of the seven world ages at this time, cf. *In IV Sent.* d.40, dub.3 (*Opera Omnia* IV, 854); and *Breviloquium*, Prol. #2 (V, 203-04).

77. The *Collationes* have come down to us in two reportations: a longer version, edited in *Opera omnia* V, 327-454; and a shorter one edited by F. Delmore, *S. Bonaventurae Collationes in Hexaemeron* (Quaracchi, 1934). The *Collationes* have received their most incisive treatment in J. Ratzinger's *Die Geschichtstheologie des heiligen Bonaventuras* (Munich, 1959). For comments on Ratzinger's work, cf. S. Classen, "Zur Geschichtstheologie Bonaventuras," *Wissenschaft und Weisheit*, 22(1959), 197-212; and J. Kaup, "Die Geschichtstheologie des heiligen Bonaventura," *Franziskanische Studien*, 42(1960), 66-81.

Only Peter John Olivi's *Postilla in Apocalypsim* can approach this astonishing work as an example of the fusion of Joachimite eschatology, Franciscan spirituality, and Scholastic passion for order. The technical procedures of Scholastic theology—*lectio*, *quaestio*, and *disputatio*—are not used here, they would be out of place in the atmosphere of the *collatio*, or familiar sermon given to the brethren; but the rich intellectual background and the powers of synthesis that Bonaventure brings to this enterprise, despite the over-rich symbolism and the incessant triple classifications, mark the *Collationes* as one of the high points of the Scholastic effort.

Leaving aside the question of Joachim's Trinitarian views, which could scarcely make an overt appearance due to the Lateran condemnation, both in the case of the theory of the scriptural senses and of the theology of history Bonaventure displays an original rethinking of the Joachimite tradition. The name of the Abbot of Fiore is never mentioned. While in itself this is not significant, it does hint to the fact that Bonaventure is using the wider Joachimite tradition throughout in a manner that makes it extremely difficult to determine if he had direct access to the authentic texts of the abbot.⁷⁸ The Franciscan does not repeat Joachim's complex theory of scriptural senses, but when he discusses his theory of how intelligence is instructed through the Scriptures,⁷⁹ he conveys a sense of further growth in the understanding of the sacred text that founds the possibility of an age of new revelation (in the sense of a further and more widespread spiritual understanding of the written text) in the future.⁸⁰ He further emphasizes that the Scriptures can only be understood by taking into account their historical dimensions,⁸¹ at times talking of the relation of the Old to the New Testament in a letter to letter manner similar to Joachim's concordances.⁸²

The Joachimite flavor is confirmed by a consideration of the doctrine of the world ages in the *Collationes*. Bonaventure mentions the traditional classifications of three ages, five ages, and seven ages⁸³—he even includes his own speculation concerning four ages;⁸⁴ but it is obviously the seven age schema to which he devotes his greatest attention.⁸⁵ Ratzinger's claim that Bonaventure's comparison of the seven ages in the history of the Old Testament with the seven ages in the history of the New stems from Joachim seems well founded;⁸⁶ even more

78. Ratzinger, *op. cit.*, 106 sqq.; and Classen, *op. cit.*, 210, both stress the importance of the intermediaries between Joachim and Bonaventure.

79. *Coll.* XIII, 2-8 (V, 388-89). On Bonaventure's theory of Scripture, cf. Ratzinger, *op. cit.*, 9-12.

80. Ratzinger's brilliant analysis of Bonaventure's concept of revelation may be found in the second chapter of his study, especially 69-70, and 94-96. This analysis does much to illuminate the confusion over Joachim's own sense of the new revelation of the third age which nevertheless will not abrogate the finality of the written Gospel. This concept appears in *Coll.* XVI, 29 (V, 408): Et dixit, quod adhuc intelligentia Scripturae daretur vel revelatio vel clavis David personae vel multitudini, et magis credo quod multitudini; and in *Coll.* XX, 15 (V, 428).

81. *Coll.* II, 17 (V, 339): Scripturae intelligi non possunt nec mysteria, nisi sciatur decursus mundi et dispositio hierarchia. *Coll.* XV, 11 (V, 400): Unde cognitio futurorum dependet ex cognitione preteritorum. *Coll.* XV, 20 (V, 401): Haec sunt semina, quae qui ignorat, scilicet haec tempora, non potest venire ad mysterium Scripturarum. This last statement is made in the context of a three age scheme of history in which the various ages are appropriated to the three Persons of the Trinity.

82. E.g., *Coll.* XV, 22 (V, 401).

83. *Coll.* XV, 12-20 (V, 400-401).

84. *Coll.* XIV, 5 (V, 393-94).

85. The whole *Collatio* XVI is a rich Joachimite treatise on the double seven ages.

86. Ratzinger, *op. cit.*, 18-19. Classen, *op. cit.*, 206-07, notes that Bonaventure's system is really a triple scheme of sevens since it includes the seven days of creation, as well as the time of the Old and New Testaments. The primordial seven days, however, play little part in Bonaventure's extensive development.

significant is his acceptance of the basic Joachite principle of concordances: "According to the comparison of the tree or of the seed to the seed, the ages mutually *succeed* each other; according to the comparison of the sprout to the source, they mutually *correspond* to each other. . . ."⁸⁷ The basically Joachite dimensions of this vision of history are heightened by two significant considerations. First of all, unlike Aquinas, but very much like Joachim, Bonaventure is willing to specify in very concrete historical fashion the boundaries and chief events of his seven periods of the history of the New Testament;⁸⁸ secondly, it is evident that the seraphic doctor expects a period of fulfillment within history that is totally alien to Aquinas but shows many points of similarity with the third age of the Abbot of Fiore.⁸⁹

Lest one think that Bonaventure has been totally converted to the viewpoint of the radical Franciscans he had condemned, however, we must note the statement in *Collatio* XVI, 2: "After the New Testament there will not be another, nor can any sacrament of the New Law be abrogated, because it is the Eternal Testament."⁹⁰ Clearly, Bonaventure is protecting his other flank—the papal condemnation of Gerardo's *Introductorius* must stand. The same judicious position is to be seen in his attitude toward the identification of the Franciscan order with the *virī spirituales* of the third age of Joachim. The saint is convinced of the superiority of the *ordo contemplantium* of the future age,⁹¹ but he refuses to identify this order with the present Franciscans: they are rather the last step in the present age towards the true *virī spirituales*.⁹² Francis, it is true, belonged to this highest order,⁹³ and thus his unique eschatological role; but on the existence of the eschatological order as a present reality, Bonaventure makes the prudent remark: "But what order that future one may be, or even if it already may exist, is not easy to know."⁹⁴ Francis' eschatological position has been maintained, but by depriving him of the honor of founding the Franciscans!

Bonaventure thus avoids the pitfalls that led to the condemnations of Gerardo and John of Parma. Despite the sense of the coming of a new age, Christ has not lost his central position in the doctor's thought.⁹⁵ Nevertheless, the saint has grown significantly more Joachite in the course of his generalate;⁹⁶ indeed, many of his ideas were to influence later representatives of the classic

87. Secundum comparationem arboris vel seminis ad semen tempora sibi mutuo succedunt; secundum comparationem germinis ad germinans mutuo sibi correspondent. . . . *Coll.* XVI, 1 (V, 403).

88. Cf. *Coll.* XVI, 11-16; 18-19; 29 (V, 405; 406; 408). Cf. Ratzinger, *op. cit.*, 29-31.

89. E.g., *Coll.* XVI, 1-2; XXIII, 4 (V, 403, 445). In the latter passage we read: Et sicut Christus in sexto tempore venit, ita oportet quod in fine generetur Ecclesia contemplativa. Cf. Ratzinger, *op. cit.*, 15.

90. *Opera Omnia* V, 403: Post novum testamentum non erit aliud, nec aliquod sacramentum novae legis subtrahi potest, quia illud testamentum aeternum est.

91. XXII, 9-10; 16; 20-22 (V, 438-39; 440; 440-41).

92. *Coll.* XXII, 21 (V, 440). Cf. Ratzinger, *op. cit.*, 48-53.

93. *Coll.* XXII, 22-23 (V, 440-41).

94. *Ibid.* Quis autem ordo iste futurus sit, vel iam sit, non est facile scire.

95. Cf. Ratzinger's summary on the relation of Bonaventure to Joachim, *op. cit.*, 106-07, and especially 119-20.

96. For other treatments of the eschatology of Bonaventure and its relation to Joachim, cf. G. Bondatti, *op. cit.*, 137-40; R. Manselli, *op. cit.*, 125-30; B. Töpfer, *op. cit.*, 149-53; L. Tondelli, *Il Libro delle Figure. I. Introduzione* (Turin, 19532), 247-59; and M. Reeves, *Prophecy in the Later Middle Ages*. . . , 66-67, 179-81. Reeves' statement that "St. Bonaventure was a Joachite *malgré lui*" (p. 181) is misleading in hinting that he was not conscious of the delicate operation he was performing. Finally, H. Grundmann in "Dante und Joachim von Floris," *Deutsches Dante-Jahrbuch*, 14(1932), 232 sqq., considered the whole of the *Collationes* to be an attack on Joachim—a view that seems scarcely supportable today.

phase of Franciscan Joachimism.⁹⁷ The reason for this shift is certainly to be sought in Bonaventure's position as the head of a vast organization one part of which was becoming more and more connected with Joachite speculation; but it is also to be discovered in events at the University of Paris. The increasing use of Aristotle and Averroes by the Arts Faculty and the influence that this had upon theology came to a head in 1270s. Bonaventure, like many others, sensed great danger in this movement and reacted strongly. What is unique to Bonaventure's reaction was to fuse the crisis of radical Aristotelianism and radical eschatology—the presence of Aristotelian errors in theology became a great eschatological sign, another compelling witness to the imminence of the passage to the next age.⁹⁸ False theologians and true spiritual men will be the opposed signs of the dawning age for the seraphic doctor.⁹⁹

III. CONCLUSIONS

In the light of the evidence presented here the conclusions that one may draw from the way in which the figure of the Abbot Joachim and the movement of Joachite thought were treated by Aquinas and Bonaventure should be largely restricted to the context of the thirteenth century church. Perhaps a more general observation may be made towards the end, if only as food for thought and discussion within the framework of the forthcoming conference.

At the very least, our brief survey allows some negative judgments to be made. Thus, E. Buonaiuti's attempt to lump Bonaventure and Aquinas together as expressing a common Scholastic reaction to the eschatological current initiated by Joachim is untenable.¹⁰⁰ In this area, the diversity of approach manifested by the two great doctors of the thirteenth century confirms the plurality evident in lesser known thinkers. T. Gregory's recent studies on the anti-historical effects of Aristotelian cosmology on Scholasticism need further investigation and clarification. The contrast between theology that is a *lectio historiae*, and hence organized around biblical and historical categories, and theology that is a *scientia consequentiarum* does not mean that the latter is always deprived of eschatological import.¹⁰¹ Y. Congar can agree that in the theology of Aquinas the *ordo historiae* is lost,¹⁰² but still make a strong case for the presence of basic traditional themes of sacred history and eschatology. Furthermore, Bonaventure's *Collationes*, manifesting such an obvious eschatological outlook, are still organized

97. Bonaventure's conception of the sixth and seventh ages as running concurrently (e.g., *Coll.* XV, 12, 18; XVI, 2) is most likely the source of Olivi's similar thoughts about the concurrence of the fifth and sixth ages; cf. G. Leff, *op. cit.*, I, 125; 131. Reference has already been made to the influence of Bonaventure's identification of Francis with the Angel of the Sixth Seal on the later tradition.

98. Ratzinger claims the anti-philosophical statements of the later Bonaventure are primarily eschatological in motivation, *op. cit.*, 121. Bonaventure first refers to false Aristotelianism as a sign of the Antichrist in 1267 in the *Collationes de Septem Donis Spiritus Sancti*, VIII, 16-20 (*Opera Omnia* V, 497-98). It is found throughout the *Collationes in Hexaemeron* in varying fashions, e.g., VI, 1-6; VII, 2-3; XVII, 25 and 28; and XIX, 12-15. On this whole problem, cf. Ratzinger's fourth chapter, especially 143-44, and 159-62.

99. Bonaventure's criticism of philosophy was of major import for later eschatologists, not least of all for Peter John Olivi. Cf. G. Leff, *op. cit.*, I, 127-28; and R. Manselli, *op. cit.*, 206-09; and J. Ratzinger, *op. cit.*, 155-56. In an eschatological treatise of Arnald of Villanova, St. Thomas has taken the place of Aristotle as the major villain, cf. F. Ehrle, "Arnaldo da Villanova ed i Thomatiste," *Gregorianum*, 1(1920), 475-501.

100. E. Buonaiuti, *op. cit.*, 294-97.

101. T. Gregory, *Escatologia e Aristotelismo*. . . , "165-67; 169; and Sull 'escatologia di Bonaventura e San Tommaso d'Aquino," 88.

102. Congar, *op. cit.*, 84.

around the a-historical and systematic theme of the seven illuminations of the intelligence.¹⁰³

Although there is then no one Scholastic reaction to the radical eschatology of Joachim of Fiore, and while we must beware of over-simplified contrasts between the Scholastic and the eschatological mentalities, there is still a tension between the two which highlights a significant problem in the history of medieval thought. Despite the cogent arguments of the Thomist scholars and the profundity of the angelic doctor's mind on any question he touched, it would be difficult to say that the historical dimension of the Christian message is a major concern in his system. He is compelled by circumstances to respond to what were for him the aberrations of the time; he does this by building upon and transforming traditional elements from patristic theology. Nevertheless, one is always given the impression that it is an aside or a polemical necessity. His true interests lie elsewhere—in the systematic reorganization of Christian theology in the light of Aristotle.

Bonaventure, on the other hand, while never abandoning a basic Scholastic approach, gradually became more and more critical of the direction in which the theological effort of his time was moving as he became more eschatological in his outlook.¹⁰⁴ From his early *Commentary on the Sentences* (which formally speaking does not differ in approach and attitude from that of Aquinas), he moved to the symbolic, Joachite, yet still Scholastic synthesis of the *Collationes in Hexaemeron* at the end of his life. One of the major motivations in this shift is located within the heart of the Scholastic enterprise itself—Bonaventure's growing suspicion concerning the use of Aristotelian philosophy as a tool for Christian theology.¹⁰⁵ Here theological protest within Scholasticism and eschatological fervor eventually stemming from Joachim reinforced each other in a remarkable way.

Another factor that exercised a decisive influence on this shift moves us in the direction of more general, and far more tentative, observations about the nature of eschatological thought and the tensions between institutions and visionaries. Bonaventure's position as the head of the Franciscan order and (despite his prudence) the undoubted Franciscan elements in his eschatological viewpoint indicate the importance of the social context in the history of eschatology in the thirteenth century. More than any other group of the time, the thirteenth century Franciscans display a history of intense interest in eschatology. Perhaps

103. Gregory does recognize the importance of the reaction of Bonaventure and his followers, cf. "Escatologia e Aristotelismo. . .," 169-74; and "Sull'escatologia. . .," 90-94. Nonetheless, he does not stress the sense in which the *Collationes* must still be spoken of as a Scholastic treatise. The contrast between the methods of organization (commentary on the Biblical *series narrationis* vs. systematic treatises organized according to *quaestiones*) is not as fundamental as the desire for new syntheses.

104. This shift towards eschatology raises the question of the unity of Scholastic thought. On varying older views on this question, cf. F. Van Steenberghen, *La Philosophie au XIII^e siècle* (Louvain-Paris, 1966), 22-24. The position adopted here affirms a general unity in terms of a movement of differentiation for the purpose of eventual synthesis. In these terms Bonaventure's *Collationes* implicitly partake of the differentiating moment and explicitly of the synthetic moment and must therefore be termed "Scholastic." J. Ratzinger is misleading when he terms Bonaventure's polemics against the false use of philosophy as anti-Scholastic (*op. cit.*, 160-61); they are rather directed against a particular *species* of Scholasticism.

105. One of the basic differences between Bonaventure and Aquinas, as Ratzinger has noted (*op. cit.*, 143-44), is in the former's refusal to adopt the Aristotelian notion of time which allowed Thomas to affirm the philosophical possibility of an eternal world.

it was just insofar as they were the most successful religious phenomenon of their age—the group with the most pronounced sense of special character and mission—that they turned with such eagerness to the nearest radical eschatology at hand.

The history of radical eschatology in the Western world is largely the history of special groups, whether *within* or *without* the ruling intellectual, ecclesiastical, and social structure. Unlike some complexes of ideas its nature is not to move in the direction of consensus. In times of desperation masses of people may briefly turn to an eschatological hope as the only way to give meaning to an impossible situation, but majority opinion is never consistently eschatological over any appreciable period of time. The most effective force behind eschatological movements are the well organized groups who find in a collective sense of being the harbingers of the future the meaning of their lives. Whether as a persecuted minority (such as the early Christians, the later Spiritual Franciscans, or the Anabaptists), or as a temporarily accepted elite (such as the Franciscans under Bonaventure), the history of eschatology is largely the history of sects and the sectarian mentality.¹⁰⁶ In this sense the growth of religious orders as identifiable social and religious entities with what might be broadly described as a sectarian mentality is a most important factor in the growth of radical eschatology in the later middle ages. The contrasts and congruencies between the eschatology of a Joachim of Fiore and the Scholastic theology of an Aquinas or a Bonaventure are as much a function of the sociology of groups of *viri spirituales* as of the purely intellectual issues involved.

106. The language, of course, cannot help but recall E. Troeltsch's profound *The Social Teaching of the Christian Churches* (Harper Torchbook ed.) I, 328-82. I hope at some future date to be able to comment upon the relation of Troeltsch's concept of "sect" to the kind of movements under consideration.